seems, I have been pursuing two mutually incompatible fates, in the worlds of public service and authorship.

Still, is it fair to saddle Hinduism with the burden of being responsible for its astrologers, many of whom are undoubtedly charlatans? Or should the belief of certain Hindus in astrology be seen as an emanation of Indian society rather than of the Hindu faith?

The latter case is undoubtedly strengthened by the Hindu affinity for gurus and godmen, whose claims to religious significance often do not extend much beyond their garb (and their gab). Hindus have flocked to ochre-robed dispensers of spiritual wisdom for centuries. There have been ascetic fakirs like Shirdi Sai Baba, performers of miracles like Sathya Sai Baba, teachers of meditation like Maharishi Mahesh Yogi and practitioners of sexual liberation like 'Bhagwan' Shri Rajneesh (who later transformed himself into the somewhat more austere Osho). The legendary Sathya Sai Baba has multiple millions of followers around the world; I have written elsewhere of the spotless town of Puttaparthi that serves as his spiritual headquarters, and continues to attract devotees years after his death. Among the 'living saints' of Hinduism, Mata Amritanandamayi, the 'hugging saint', is revered as the embodiment of unconditional love. Her ashram and spiritual retreat, Amritapuri in Vallikavu near Kollam, is a beehive of activity, thronged with followers from around the world; like Sathya Sai Baba, she channels the donations of her followers to major social welfare projects, running a university, medical college, hospital and a television studio.

Such revered figures follow in a long-established Hindu tradition. Advaita Vedantist Hindus have traditionally held gurus or teachers in high reverence, since many ancient texts suggest that one should seek a qualified and able guide in the pursuit of one's spiritual quest. Following a guru is thus seen by many Hindus as desirable though not mandatory, a path to an end rather than an end in itself; a guru is a guide towards the fulfilment of self-realisation, not a substitute for it. In the Advaita tradition, a competent teacher is vital to help a seeker attain correct knowledge and freedom from false knowledge; he (or occasionally she) serves as a revered instructor, counsellor, and shaper of their disciples' values. Since Hinduism emphasises *anubhava*, or the knowledge that